Thankfulness we can put into words

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

להודות ולהלל לשמך הגדול

To thank and praise Your great name.

Al HaNissim for Chanukah, concluding words | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

Al HaNissim tells of Hashem helping the Jewish people when they faced powerful enemies. It remembers their return to the Beit HaMikdash and ends with thanks and praise. Chanukah is more than receiving gifts or eating a favorite food: we practice noticing, remembering, and thanking. Family connection: a specific thank-you shows that we noticed what someone actually did.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

We add Al HaNissim in the Amidah and Birkat HaMazon. If it was forgotten, we do not repeat the entire prayer or Birkat HaMazon just for that omission. Ask an adult to help you find its place in the siddur or birkon your family uses.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Find Al HaNissim together, then each give a specific thank-you to another person: name what they did and how it helped. Finish by naming one thing for which your family thanks Hashem.

Younger learners: Finish: Thank you for helping me with...
Older learners: What is the difference between thanking someone for help and praising a quality they showed?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Name one prayer in which we add Al HaNissim. 2. Must we repeat the whole prayer just because we forgot Al HaNissim?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Read the Chanukah paragraph of Al HaNissim on the reverse. Find a phrase about the struggle, a phrase about Hashem's help, and a phrase about the people's response. Explain why the prayer includes all three.

Sources: Al HaNissim for Chanukah, concluding words; Al HaNissim and omissions: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 682:1.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Al HaNissim | Chanukah paragraph

Chanukah paragraph, one printed nusach; family siddur wording may differ

בימי מתתיהו בן יוחנן כהן גדול חשמונאי ובניו, כשעמדה מלכות יון הרשעה על עמך ישראל להשכיחם תורתך ולהעבירם מחקי רצונך, ואתה ברחמיך הרבים עמדת להם בעת צרתם, רבת את ריבם, דנת את דינם, נקמת את נקמתם, מסרת גבורים ביד חלשים, ורבים ביד מעטים, וטמאים ביד טהורים, ורשעים ביד צדיקים, וזדים ביד עוסקי תורתך, ולך עשית שם גדול וקדוש בעולמך, ולעמך ישראל עשית תשועה גדולה ופרקן כהיום הזה. ואחר כך באו בניך לדביר ביתך, ופנו את היכלך, וטהרו את מקדשך, והדליקו נרות בחצרות קדשך, וקבעו שמונת ימי חנכה אלו, להודות ולהלל לשמך הגדול.

In the days of Mattityahu son of Yochanan, the Kohen Gadol, the Chashmonai, and his sons, the wicked Greek kingdom rose against Your people Israel to make them forget Your Torah and turn them away from the laws of Your will. In Your great mercy, You stood by them in their distress. You fought their struggle, judged their case, and avenged them. You delivered the strong into the hands of the weak, the many into the hands of the few, the impure into the hands of the pure, the wicked into the hands of the righteous, and the arrogant into the hands of those who study Your Torah. You made Yourself a great and holy name in Your world, and brought Your people Israel great salvation and deliverance, as on this day. Afterward, Your children entered the inner chamber of Your House, cleared Your Sanctuary, purified Your Temple, and lit lamps in Your holy courtyards. They established these eight days of Chanukah to thank and praise Your great name.

2. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 682:1 | Where it belongs

Opening sentences; later details about remembering mid-blessing omitted

כל שמונת ימי חנוכה אומר על הנסים בברכת המזון בברכת הארץ ובתפלה בברכת מודים. ואם לא אמר אין מחזירין אותו.

On all eight days of Chanukah, one says Al HaNissim in Birkat HaMazon, in the blessing for the land, and in the Amidah, in the blessing of thanksgiving. If one did not say it, one does not repeat.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Find a phrase about the struggle, a phrase about Hashem's help, and a phrase about the people's response. Use your own siddur's nusach when praying.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.